Structuring your communications

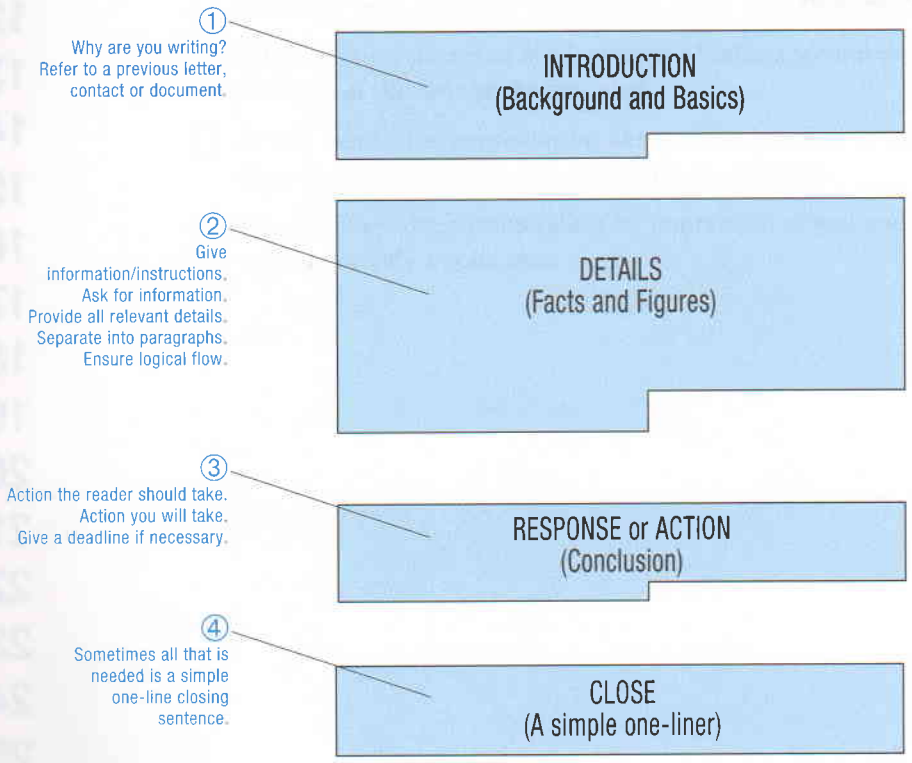
4 point plan

Checklist

Whether you are composing a business letter, a fax message, a memo or an e-mail, the general rules for structuring the body of the message are the same. A well-structured document written in good business language is the core of effective communication. This section will help you to get past that blank page and start creating well-structured documents that will achieve your objectives.

4 POINT PLAN

Many communications are short and routine. You can write or dictate them without any special thinking or preparation. However, documents that are not so routine need more thought and careful planning. I first suggested this 4 point plan in *Communication for Business*. It provides a useful but simple framework for structuring all written communications, and is illustrated simply here:



Let's look at this 4 point plan in more detail:

1 Opening or introduction

The first paragraph will state the reason for the communication, basically setting the scene. It may:

- acknowledge previous correspondence
- refer to a meeting or contact
- provide an introduction to the matter being discussed.

Examples

Thank you for your letter of ...
It was good to meet you again at last week's conference.
We wish to hold our annual conference at a London hotel in September.



Beware beginning a sentence with 'Further to your letter of ...' This should always be continued as shown:

Further to your letter of 12 July, I am sorry for the delay in attending to this matter.

2 Central section (details)

This main part of the message gives all the information that the recipient needs to know. Alternatively you may be requesting information, sometimes both. Details should be stated simply and clearly, with separate paragraphs used for individual sections. This section should flow logically to a natural conclusion.

3 Conclusion (Action or Response)

This section draws the message to a logical conclusion. It may:

- state the action expected from the recipient
- state the action you will take as a result of the details provided.

Examples

Please let me have full details of the costs involved together with some sample menus.

If payment is not received within seven days this matter will be placed in the hands of our solicitor.

4 Close

A simple one-line closing sentence is usually all that is necessary to conclude a message. This should be relevant to the content of the message.

Examples

I look forward to meeting you soon.

I look forward to seeing you at next month's conference.

A prompt reply would be appreciated.

Please let me know if you need any further information.

TIP **Closes such as these are incomplete and should not be used:**

Hope to hear from you soon.
Looking forward to hearing from you.

The 4 point plan for structuring all written messages is illustrated in this letter.

Institute of Secretaries
Wilson House, West Street, London SW1 2AR

Telephone 020 8987 2432
Fax 020 8987 2556

LD/ST

12 May 2004

Miss Ong Lee Fong
15 Windsor Road
Manchester
M2 9GJ

Dear Lee Fong

2004 SECRETARIES CONFERENCE, 8/9 OCTOBER 2004

Opening (give a brief introduction)

As a valued member of the Institute of Secretaries, I have pleasure in inviting you to attend our special conference to be held at the Clifton Hotel, London on Tuesday/Wednesday 8/9 October 2004.

This intensive, practical conference for professional secretaries aims to:

Details (separate paragraphs, flowing logically)

- increase your managerial and office productivity
- improve your communication skills
- bring you up to date with the latest technology and techniques
- enable networking with other secretaries

Leave one blank line everywhere except the signature space

The seminar is power-packed with a distinguished panel of professional speakers who will give expert advice on many useful topics. A programme is enclosed giving full details of this seminar which I know you will not want to miss.

Conclusion (action expected from the recipient)

If you would like to join us please complete the enclosed registration form and return it to me before 30 June with your fee of £50 per person.

Close (a simple closing statement)

I look forward to seeing you again at this exciting conference.

Yours sincerely

Louise Dunscombe

LOUISE DUNSCOMBE (Mrs)
Conference Secretary

Encs

This e-mail message gives another example of the 4 point plan.

From	johnwang@stelectronics.co.sg
Date	14:10:03 12:30:45
To	suzieliu@videoworks.com
CC	
Subject	24th anniversary video

Dear Suzie

Intro — Thank you for inviting me to visit your studios last week. I was most impressed by your new facilities.

Details — I am delighted that you can accept our invitation to produce a video to celebrate the company's 25th anniversary. This is a very special landmark in our history, and it is important that this video portrays both past, present and future.

Action — You promised to let me have a draft outlining your thoughts for this special video. I look forward to receiving this before 30 October together with your approximate costings.

If you need any further information please give me a call on 2757272.

Close — Best wishes

John Wang
Marketing Manager
ST Electronics
www.stelectronics.co.sg

TIP **Study all the documents in this book as good examples of using the 4 point plan.**